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CPS plans to cut teaching staff

Exact number of eliminated positions unclear as district tries to close \$732.5 million deficit

By **Kate Armanini**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Public Schools is planning to cut teaching staff to help close a \$732.5 million deficit as it rolls out school-level budgets for next year, though the exact number of eliminated positions across the district remains unclear.

At a media briefing Tuesday, CPS

leaders said teacher losses will be capped at four per elementary school and six per high school as the district adjusts its staffing allocation formulas. Class size limits will remain unchanged, officials said, citing several years of declining enrollment.

Principals are slated to receive their school's budgets this week, as the cash-strapped district faces

rising costs, increased student need and stagnant state funding. The full fiscal year 2027 budget is expected to be presented in mid-summer and must win school board approval by the end of August.

"We knew coming in that this would not be an easy budget cycle," CPS CEO Macqueline Kingsaid. "We have to make decisions based on the revenue sources that we have, and not the revenue we wish we had."

The district did not share the total number of positions that will be cut, or the projected savings from

staffing reductions, partly because principals can choose to use discretionary funding to hire additional teachers.

Acting chief budget officer Emila Zoko said she expects overall school funding levels to remain "roughly equal," but that resources will be allocated differently — largely because special education and English-language learner enrollment have grown, even as overall enrollment has declined.

Officials are planning significant cuts to central office and adminis-

trative departments, stressing that their priority is to shield classrooms from further reductions. The budget is based on a projected \$100 million in surplus funding from Tax Increment Financing districts.

The district's smallest schools will also lose funding for assistant principals. A CPS spokesperson noted that principals can appeal their school staffing levels and said those numbers are not yet finalized. But Kia Banks, president of the

See **CPS** on Page A4



E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Soccer stadium to be McDonald's Park

The 22,000-seat Chicago Fire soccer stadium is under construction at the north end of The 78 development in Chicago's South Loop on Tuesday. McDonald's has acquired naming rights for the new stadium, which will be called McDonald's Park. **Business**

Non-Equity Jeff Awards suspended for '26-'27 season

Several companies said they would not invite committee to shows

By **Chris Jones**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Joseph Jefferson Awards Committee said Tuesday that it will suspend giving Jeff Awards in its non-Equity sector for the 2026-27 season.

The decision follows the announcement by several theater companies, including Idle Muse Theatre, Strawdog Theatre, Ghostlight Theatre Ensemble, Factory Theatre and others, that they would not invite the all-volunteer committee to their shows as a protest against an award being given to director Charles Askenazer of Invictus Theatre at the 2026 Non-Equity Jeff Awards in March.

Askenazer was accused on social media of inappropriately aggressive and invasive rehearsal behavior during a prior production in 2021. He has denied those allegations, which do not appear to allege sexual misconduct and have not resulted in any formal charges or known lawsuits. The board of Invictus Theatre has not yet announced the results of its ongoing investigation into the situation. Askenazer stepped away from the theater he co-founded in the interim.

See **AWARDS** on Page A6



Ald. Ronnie Mosley, 21st, left, and Ald. Walter "Red" Burnett, 27th, speak after a City Council meeting on Jan. 21 at Chicago City Hall. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Aldermen advance tipped wage raise delay after Johnson's veto

Deal delivers blow to victory mayor claimed last month

By **Jake Sheridan**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago aldermen advanced a plan Tuesday to slow planned raises for workers like waiters making a subminimum tipped wage, shortly after Mayor Brandon Johnson vetoed an effort to completely block the increases.

The change to the city's

"One Fair Wage" ordinance would halt the raises for two years in larger Chicago restaurants, while making workers in smaller restaurants wait four years for the pay bumps.

The deal delivers a blow to the victory Johnson claimed just last month when he vetoed a City Council majority that had voted to pass an indefinite freeze — and likely sets up future showdowns over the raises for tipped workers.

"It's hard to believe that this is a fully settled matter," chief

sponsor Ald. Walter "Red" Burnett, 27th, said after the City Council workforce committee aldermen approved the change in a voice vote. "But it gives us time to protect workers."

Burnett argued "most people are comfortable" with the compromise deal. During Tuesday's meeting, both the Illinois Restaurant Association and One Fair Wage national campaign told aldermen they believed the change was acceptable, but

See **DELAY** on Page A6

Both GOP and Dems grill Hegseth on Iran war

Lawmakers wary of low munitions levels, tensions with allies

By **Ben Finley, Konstantin Toropin, Bill Barrow and Stephen Groves**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth faced tough questions Tuesday from Republican and Democratic lawmakers about the Trump administration's end game for the Iran war, the conflict's rising \$29 billion cost and its impact on diminishing U.S. weapons stockpiles.

While the Pentagon chief softened his tone from hearings before Congress nearly two weeks ago, notably avoiding the same pointed criticism of lawmakers, he got far more pushback from members of his own Republican Party about the levels of U.S. munitions used in the Iran war and President Donald Trump's intense criticism of traditional allies for not taking part in the conflict.

"I take issue with the characterization that munitions are depleted in a public forum," Hegseth said. "That's not true."

Even as he insisted that the U.S. military has plenty of missile defense systems and other munitions for the Iran war or future conflicts, Hegseth told House and Senate lawmakers overseeing defense spending that the Trump administration is working to ramp up production of weapons.

Pentagon officials also told lawmakers that the cost of the Iran war has risen to about \$29 billion, the vast bulk of which — roughly \$24 billion — is related to replac-

See **HEGSETH** on Page A6

INSIDE

The Readers' Choice Food Awards winners

Many of this year's winners have embraced the idea of being more than just places that offer great food and drink. They're also welcoming spaces where the community can gather to support each other. **Food & Health**

Column on media in Chicago debuts

Robert Channick writes about Fox 32's new sports anchor, WGN's stalled merger and the final bell for CBS Radio at WBBM in the first installment of his biweekly Chicago Media Report. **Business**

Vallas fined \$214,000 for finance violations

Former mayoral candidate Paul Vallas faces fine for violating campaign finance rules by accepting excessive contributions from people doing business with the city. **Chicagoland, Page A2**

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 62 L: 44
THU. H: 66 L: 51
FRI. H: 73 L: 61
Complete details on Page A14

INDEX

Almanac A2
Arts & Living B8
Comics B12-B13
Crossword B13
Editorials A6
Horoscope B12
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A10
Television B11

178th year No. 133
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